PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #56 · PTSD

“I have no control. If it happened once, nothing I do can stop it from happening again.”

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Where it often comes from

Helplessness is one of the hardest parts of being hurt. If you could not stop it, the mind may decide you can never stop anything like it. “I have no control” feels true because, in that moment, you did not. The lie makes that moment the rule for every future moment. You still cannot control other people’s choices. You can have choices now: a boundary, a call, a counselor, a next step. Those are small, and they are real. A counselor can help you work with this at a pace that is safe. You do not have to do it alone, or all at once.

What Scripture teaches

God does not say you were in control of the waters or the fire. He says when you pass through them, He is with you, and they will not overwhelm you. He will not leave you. He is a refuge and strength. Christ gives strength. The Protector of Israel does not sleep. None of this gives you a button to rewind what happened. It does mean “nothing I do can ever matter” is larger than the truth. You are not God, and you are not powerless in the life you have now.

> *“When you pass through the waters, I will be with you; and when you go through the rivers, they will not overwhelm you. When you walk through the fire, you will not be scorched; the flames will not set you ablaze”* (Isaiah 43:2).

Also see

> “The LORD Himself goes before you; He will be with you. He will never leave you nor forsake you. Do not be afraid or discouraged” (Deuteronomy 31:8).

> “God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in times of trouble” (Psalm 46:1).

> “I can do all things through Christ who gives me strength” (Philippians 4:13).

> “He will not allow your foot to slip; your Protector will not slumber. Behold, the Protector of Israel will neither slumber nor sleep” (Psalm 121:3–4).

Common self-statements

- If it happened once, it will happen no matter what I do.
- Trying is pointless.
- I am a passenger in my own life.
- Other people have choices. I do not.
- Safety depends on me controlling everything, and I cannot.
- I should not bother.

Common logical errors

- Overgeneralization: Turning one helpless moment into “I can never affect anything.”
- Fortune telling: Deciding the next chapter is already fixed because the last one was.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Either I control everything or I control nothing.
- Discounting the positive: Ignoring the choices, helps, and boundaries you do have now.

Challenging questions

- What was truly outside my control then?
- What is one choice I do have today?
- Am I trying to control other people so I can feel safe?
- What would a small boundary look like?
- Where does God promise to be when I cannot steer the outcome?
- What step has my counselor said is mine to take, and what is not?

Truth summary

> I could not control what happened. I am not powerless now. God is with me, and I can take one real step today.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

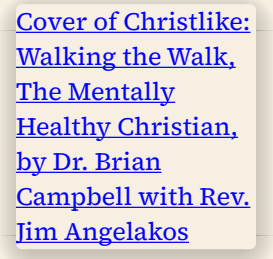
- Fear
- Trust
- Anxiety/Worry
- Thinking, Healthy
- God, All Powerful

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Trouble/Hardship
- Thinking, Healthy

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Greater — MercyMe
You do not have to control what already happened in order to be held.

Same Power — Jeremy Camp
God's power is present where yours ran out.

More Than Conquerors — Steven Curtis Chapman
Not being in control of the past is not the same as being defeated now.

Victory in Jesus — Joy Gardner, Cynthia Clawson, Mike Allen and Reggie Smith
Christ's victory does not depend on you having stopped what happened.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I have no control. If it happened once, nothing I do can stop it from happening again."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I have no control. If it happened once, nothing I do can stop it from happening again." I believe this _____ %
(0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What was truly outside my control then?
- ☐ What is one choice I do have today?
- ☐ Am I trying to control other people so I can feel safe?
- ☐ What would a small boundary look like?
- ☐ Where does God promise to be when I cannot steer the outcome?
- ☐ What step has my counselor said is mine to take, and what is not?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I could not control what happened. I am not powerless now. God is with me, and I can take one real step today.
- ☐ Not controlling the past is not the same as having no choices now.
- ☐ God is with me in what I cannot steer.
- ☐ I can choose one safe step without controlling other people.
- ☐ Strength is given. I do not have to invent it.
- ☐ A boundary is a form of power.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Isaiah 43:2
  "When you pass through the waters, I will be with you; and when you go through the rivers, they will not overwhelm you. When you walk through the fire, you will not be scorched; the flames will not set you ablaze."
- ☐ Deuteronomy 31:8
  "The LORD Himself goes before you; He will be with you. He will never leave you nor forsake you. Do not be afraid or discouraged."
- ☐ Psalm 46:1
  "God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in times of trouble."

A verse I found myself:

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When you felt you had no choices: Each day, write down one moment when everything felt already decided. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Isaiah 43:2 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I could not stop the waters. God is with me in them, and I still have a step I can take.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Trust" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] List two kinds of control. Write what you cannot control, and one thing you can, such as a boundary or a phone call.
- [ ] Take that one step this week. Keep it small and safe. Tell your counselor if it stirs you up.
- [ ] Do not rehearse powerlessness. When the sentence starts, add, "That was then. Today I can ___."
- [ ] Pray Isaiah 43:2 without asking to become the one who controls everything.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I have no control. If it happened once, nothing I do can stop it from happening again.": _____ %

My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A choice I still had
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I have no control. If it happened once, nothing I do can stop it from happening again~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I could not stop what happened, and I have called myself powerless ever since. Be with me. Show me the one step that is actually mine, and give me strength to take it. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.